

Exit as Disengagement: The Political Implications of Economic Migration in Rural India

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Abstract

How does migration transform citizen-state relations in developing countries? This paper examines the long-run effects of internal migration on household political engagement in left behind areas. I argue that migration helps households self-insure against economic uncertainty but siphons away political spearheads, weakening the incentives and capacity of those left behind to participate in politics. I develop and test this argument in India using a novel panel dataset that tracked more than 8,000 rural households over a 16-year period, and an original household survey in a high-migration corridor (N=1,686). Using a difference-in-differences design, I show that household migration reduces contact with elected officials and depresses engagement in community affairs. Survey evidence further corroborates these findings: members of migrant households are systematically less likely to vote, campaign, protest, and contest local elections compared to their non-migrant counterparts. These findings underscore an overlooked political cost of migration with important implications for democratic accountability.

Key words: Migration; Self-insurance; Political brain drain, Political disengagement; Democratic accountability; Left behind regions; India

Word Count: 9,892

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1. Introduction

How does internal migration transform citizen-state relations in left behind areas? Millions of households across the developing world rely on temporary economic migration to navigate economic uncertainty. Migration is central to household risk diversification in rural areas (Rosenzweig 1988; Stark and Lucas 1988; Coffey, Papp, and Spears 2015; Morten 2019). While a large fraction of the world's migrants move across international borders, many more migrate internally within their own countries. Globally, the population of internal migrants is estimated to be around 763 million, indicating that the phenomenon affects at least three times as many people as transnational migration (UNDESA 2013). Climate change is projected to intensify these internal movements, as slow-onset disasters push families to diversify risk and move to areas offering greater economic opportunities and non-farm livelihood options (Rigaud et al. 2018; Bermeo et al., 2022). Yet, while the economic and welfare effects of these demographic shifts are well-documented, their political effects in left behind regions remain relatively understudied.

This paper examines the long-run political effects of internal migration in areas left behind by economic globalization and urbanization (Collier 2025). In low-income contexts where permanent relocation is costly, circular migration enables households to cope with economic uncertainty. I argue while this strategy is rational and economically beneficial for households, it carries an overlooked political cost in the form of broad-based disengagement from local civic and political life. This disengagement effect operates through two distinct channels. First, because migration functions as an informal risk-sharing mechanism, it helps families smooth consumption and self-insure against

local economic shocks (Yang and Choi 2007; Morten 2019). A large motivation to engage the state in low- and middle-income countries is claim-making for basic material goods and services—both for short-term relief and long-term well-being (Kruks-Wisner 2018a). When households use remittances to meet these needs directly, migration weakens the underlying distributive motivation for political activism, reducing not just demands on the state but broader engagement with politics. Second, migrants are seldom a random subset of sending communities—migration selectively removes from households their most politically active members, whom I call ‘political spearheads.’ The departure of these individuals strips households and communities of individuals that drive local political engagement.

I develop this argument in India, the world’s largest democracy, home to an estimated 100 million internal economic migrants. For a variety of reasons, India offers the ideal empirical setting to illustrate this argument. First, circularity is a common but understudied form of migration in emerging economies like India. Instead of relocating to destination areas, migrant families remain in the village even as migrants move to their worksites (Thachil 2017). Migrants retain strong ties to their home communities, sending regular remittances to support their families. This dynamic makes it possible for me to examine how migration affects the political behavior of left behind households, which would be infeasible if the entire household migrated. Second, labor migration in India is overwhelmingly male-dominated and primarily consists of young men seeking work in the urban informal economy (National Sample Survey 2007-08, A-75). Due to this gender and age-selectivity, left behind households are disproportionately composed of women and the elderly.

To evaluate my argument, I draw on a unique nationally representative panel study, the Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS), which surveyed more than 8,000 rural Indian households over a 16-year period. Using a difference-in-differences design, I first demonstrate that household migration reduces political engagement among left behind members. Specifically, households that transition to migrant status between survey waves approach local elected officials for assistance at lower rates and attend community meetings less often compared to households that remained non-migrant throughout the panel. Next, I provide additional evidence for these disengagement effects across a wider array of outcomes using fine-grained data from an original survey of 1,686 households. I find that household migration has a robust negative effect on political activism across a range of electoral and non-electoral domains, including voting, campaigning, and protesting.

To explore the mechanisms for disengagement, I examine how remittances shape benefit-claiming behavior within migrant households, and whether migrants differ from those they leave behind on attributes that predict political activism. Consistent with a substitution mechanism, remittances moderate the effect of migration on claim-making—households that receive larger remittance transfers claim government benefits at lower rates. Migration also siphons away individuals who are most likely to contribute to local civic and political life. Suggestive evidence aligns with this view: migrant households are significantly less likely to field a candidate for an official position in village council elections. I also find, in line with the political brain drain literature, that migrants and non-migrants differ on key political attributes that matter for civic and political

engagement: migrants score higher on political knowledge and efficacy tests than left behind individuals.

This paper makes several contributions. First, it adds to a vibrant tradition of scholarship in political economy that examines how mass migration undermines formal accountability mechanisms in sending societies (Hirschman 1978; Goodman and Hiskey 2008; Germano 2018; De Vries et al. 2024). In contexts where local governments are constrained by corruption, clientelism, and limited state capacity, my work shows how access to migration opportunities can undercut the ability of communities to hold governments accountable for effective service delivery. By providing citizens with a low-cost exit option, migration can create perverse incentives for states to outsource their welfare obligations to diaspora networks and deflect demands for far-reaching institutional and policy reform.

Second, in line with recent work on migrant selection and geographic sorting (Lim 2023; Lueders 2023; Dancygier et al. 2025), my work underscores the importance of ‘who migrates’ for our understanding the political consequences of migration in origin areas. By examining the attributes of migrants relative to those left behind, I show that migration can alter the demographic and political composition of left behind areas in ways that increase political inequality.

Third, my findings reveal an understudied political cost of labor circulation as a development strategy that much of the existing literature on international migration has overlooked—the erosion of political voice in out-migration areas. The idea that migrants

act as conduits of democratic diffusion and agents of economic development in sending communities has been advanced by several multilateral institutions and international development agencies (World Bank 2018b; UNDP 2024). Much of this scholarship assumes that migrants are exposed to more democratic institutions at their destinations or return with sufficient savings to make productive investments at home. My findings invite us to reconsider some of these long-held assumptions, and to seriously consider the possibility that labor circulation, while economically beneficial for migrant households, may keep left behind regions locked into development traps.

2. Theory

Migration is a defining feature of household risk diversification in developing countries. It is a strategic response to macroeconomic uncertainty in rural areas, which are characterized by limited employment prospects in the non-farm economy, weak credit and insurance markets, and poor welfare provision by states (Rosenzweig 1988; Massey 1988; Stark and Lucas 1988; Yang 2011; Morten 2019). In such contexts, informal risk-sharing arrangements, typically organized around family or kinship networks, play a critical role in mitigating risk and reducing economic uncertainty. Households typically employ a variety of strategies to manage risk, including securing loans from self-help groups (Hoffmann et al. 2021), augmenting precautionary savings (Mody, Ohnsorge, and Sandri 2012), contributing to informal community institutions (MacLean 2014), and engaging in temporary migration (De Weerd and Hirvonen 2013; Morten 2019). Temporary migration, however, is becoming increasingly salient to how rural households cope with risk, as slow-onset climate change and rising agricultural stress diminish economic opportunities in rural areas and push millions to seek work in cities (World Bank 2018a).

Migrant remittances, the money that migrants send back to support their families, are not just an economic lifeline for rural households in the Global South. These financial transfers have important microeconomic and welfare effects for low-income families. An extensive literature in development economics indicates that remittances don't just help households cope with extreme poverty (Housen, Hopkins, and Earnest 2013) and stabilize consumption patterns (Combes and Ebeke 2011), but also spur investments in human capital. Studies suggest that families that receive remittances tend to spend more on education (Askarov and Doucouliagos 2020) and healthcare (Berloff and Giunti 2019) than those that don't. Yet, while migration allows households to smooth consumption and self-insure, it also reshapes how those left behind engage with politics.

2.1 Why remittances fuel political disengagement

One way in which migration can reduce incentives for political activism is by enabling households to meet their welfare needs directly instead of demanding it from the state. For citizens of developing democracies, a large motivation to engage the state and participate in politics is claim-making for basic material goods and services—both for short-term relief and long-term well-being (Auerbach et al. 2018; Kruks-Wisner 2018b). When households have access to regular remittances, they may find it more efficient to self-provide basic services through private channels instead of seeking them from the state, especially when doing so lowers the transaction costs associated with navigating complex bureaucratic procedures and dealing with unresponsive politicians. From the perspective of democratic accountability, remittances should reduce financial incentives to engage the state if migration becomes the default strategy for households to meet local welfare and development needs (Goodman and Hiskey 2008; Adida and Girod 2011).

Migrant remittances are arguably one of the most stable and enduring forms of economic support for low-income households in developing countries (Ratha 2023). In 2022, the global remittance market was valued at \$800 billion, with 80% of these funds directed towards low- and middle-income countries (UNCTAD, 2023). As a form of private income that is difficult to tax, remittances directly flow into household budgets. These money flows are not only remarkably resilient and less volatile than private capital flows, but also countercyclical (Mohapatra, Joseph, and Ratha 2009; Ratha 2023). This countercyclicality aligns with their role as an insurance mechanism, given that they help mitigate disruptions to household consumption patterns caused by exogenous weather shocks, natural disasters, and political conflicts.

These dual properties of monetary remittances—short-term consumption-smoothing and long-term self-insurance—are pivotal to understanding how these financial flows impact political incentives and behaviors of recipients. First, remittances enable families to smooth consumption by compensating them for income deficits (Rapoport and Docquier 2005; Yang and Choi 2007; Combes and Ebeke 2010). In the short-term, these financial transfers offer essential economic relief to low-income families, enabling them to fulfill basic subsistence needs such as food, clothing, and housing. Households may also allocate remittances towards long-term investments, including paying for children's education, meeting healthcare expenses, purchasing farm equipment, and starting businesses (Berloff and Giunti 2019; Askarov and Doucouliagos 2020; Bossavie and Özden 2022).

Second, because remittances act as an informal risk-sharing mechanism, studies

suggest that they often substitute for social assistance programs and public services provided by governments (Abdih et al. 2012; Konte 2016; Doyle 2015; De Vries et al. 2024). Remittances are a significant source of social security for recipients, augmenting households' capacity to endure severe economic hardship and adverse personal circumstances due to chronic unemployment, disability, or old age (Goldring 2004). More importantly, they provide exogenous resources that make it possible for households to privately purchase basic social services—such as education and healthcare—that are either non-existent or inadequately provided by governments in developing countries. These transfers therefore not only function as private safety nets that insure households against negative income shocks, but also function as substitutes for the limited and low-quality public goods that local governments provide in underserved areas.

Qualitative evidence from my focus groups reveals how remittances enable households to seek individualized private solutions to fulfil their welfare needs. In one of these focus groups, one participant reported their village facing acute shortages of drinking water. When I asked whether they had contacted the local councilor for a resolution, I was met with a sigh that conveyed both deep cynicism and profound disappointment with the local administration. He explained that the councilor did not care to listen to their grievances, which had prompted them to take matters in their own hands.²

“Whenever we encounter problems, we try solving them ourselves by finding our

²Focus group discussion, Madhubani, Bihar, October 3, 2021.

own [private] solutions. For instance, when we face a shortage of drinking water, a few of us pool our resources to dig a borewell so we can extract groundwater to meet our drinking needs. That's how things work here.”

Participants in another focus group framed migration as a pathway to social mobility. One informant described how remittances had improved their family’s quality of life, enabling them to enroll their children in private schools, a preference driven by the widespread perception that government schools lack qualified teachers³:

“If we don’t migrate, how will we provide for our families? Migration has allowed us to lead a dignified life. My grandson is pursuing his studies, and we can afford to send our children to private schools. We want them to receive a good education.”

As another illuminating excerpt from one of my focus groups reveals, remittances had enabled resource-scarce communities to build a road, in some ways compensating for a non-existent public good that the state was expected to provide:⁴

“Thanks to migration, this area has experienced some progress. Not very long ago, there wasn’t a single *sadak* [paved road] in this settlement. Now, we have some semblance of a road ... People who live and work outside return with deep pockets,

³Focus group discussion, Madhubani, Bihar. October 1, 2023.

⁴Focus group discussion, Madhubani, Bihar, October 3, 2023.

and they had the road built.”

This qualitative insight is consistent with the notion that remittances substitute for social services traditionally provided by governments. To the extent that migration reduces households’ reliance on the state by providing private resources for self-provision, left behind households should have fewer incentives to engage local elected officials to seek help with a problem or participate in discussions over community improvement compared to their non-migrant counterparts.

H1 (Claim-making) Household migration reduces the likelihood that left behind members will approach local elected officials to seek help with a problem

H2 (Community engagement) Household migration reduces participation in *gram sabhas* (community meetings)

When remittances become the primary source of economic and welfare support for left behind households, they undercut the incentive to engage the state as a way to seek welfare benefits or advocate for improved public services. To the extent that remittances substitute for state-provided benefits, households receiving larger remittance transfers should claim government benefits at lower rates than those receiving smaller transfers:

H3 (Substitution) Within migrant households, larger remittance transfers will be associated with lower benefit-claiming from the state

2.2 Removal of political spearheads

Migration also causes significant disruption to household and community structures. The massive outflows of migrant labor from villages to cities can fragment families, depopulate villages, and disintegrate communities (Lu 2019; Wu and Ye 2016; Upadhyay 2024). Regions experiencing persistent migration must contend with the absence of their most economically productive members. Typically, households send their younger and more educated members to migrate (UNESCO 2018a). In areas where migration is the predominant response to economic stagnation, migrants assume the role of guardians and providers for their families. The departure of these individuals can change demographic composition of the local population, with the elderly, children, and women constituting a disproportionately high share of those left behind (Biao 2007; Desai and Banerji 2008; UNESCO 2018b).

Beyond their role as economic providers, migrants also act as political spearheads for their households. Would-be migrants tend to be more vocal and politically engaged than those who stay behind, and their departure leaves remaining households with a diminished capacity for political action. When families lose their most politically active members to migration, they lose their political spearheads. Evidence from my qualitative fieldwork aligns closely with this political brain drain logic. A focus group discussion with members of the Musahar community, marginalized Dalit caste in Bihar, reveals that migrants are often the more efficacious and politically knowledgeable members of their households. I noted that while migrants desired their family members to be more active

in local politics, this was seldom the case⁵:

“The government tries to help us a lot, but the people here lack the ability to claim their rights. There are hardly any people in this village who can help residents secure government benefits for the poor. For this reason, I keep nudging my brother to form a union. These fellows do not want to build unions. I asked my younger brother to form a union with 100 men in the village. I told him that *safai karamcharis* (sanitation workers) would gain a voice if they had a union. Their voice will carry some weight. Nobody will be able fleece even a *chawanni* (quarter rupee) out of you guys (addressing other focus group members). I have tried to explain this to him so many times, but he just won’t do it! Let us say, I migrate to the city tomorrow. If there’s a union of 100 men in this village, nobody will dare rob me of my dues ... The other day a few women came to survey our hamlet. They were here to obtain information about the financial status of households to determine if they were eligible to receive benefits under the Public Distribution Scheme. Once the survey was done, they let us know that we would receive a kilogram of rice for 5 rupees. They did not assign us to the BPL (Below Poverty Line) category despite our household meeting the eligibility criteria.”

Participants were noticeably upset about this. They complained that they had been fleeced and unfairly assigned to the APL (Above Poverty Line) household category, essentially disqualifying them from receiving food grain at more subsidized BPL rates

⁵ Focus group discussion, Madhubani, Bihar, 1 October 2023.

meant for ultra-poor households. I probed further to inquire whether anyone from the household had contacted someone to register a formal complaint. To this end, the migrant reiterated his earlier claim about the importance of collective action:

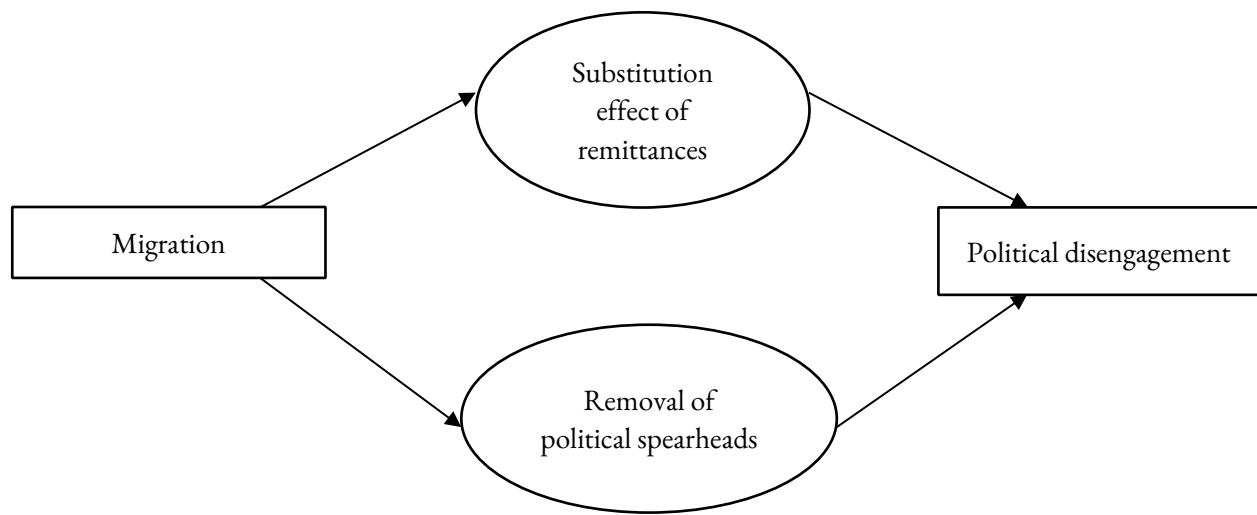
“This is why I insist that we must form a union—Why would the local authorities listen to a lone voice? Would they? When ten people rally together and put pressure on them, only then will they take some action.”

In another focus group, a returnee explained to me that being vocal and civically engaged was necessary to protect welfare benefits from being expropriated by government officials. My informant spoke of the difficulties members of his community faced in claiming benefits under the state’s crop insurance scheme, which provides insurance coverage to households against crop failures from non-preventable risks, such as natural disasters.⁶

“Take the *Fasal Bima Yojana* (crop insurance scheme). Many residents secured benefits under the program. Those who were vocal and indicated that they would fight to claim their benefits received a fair share of compensation under the law. Those who were reluctant to speak up, their money came, but the BDO (Block Development Officer) siphoned it away. There is no accountability on their part.”

⁶ Focus group discussion, Madhubani, Bihar, 3 October 2023.

Figure 2.1: How economic migration fosters political disengagement in left behind areas



My theoretical expectations and qualitative insights lead me to pose the following hypotheses:

H4 (Formal politics) Household migration reduces the likelihood that left behind members will vote and campaign during local elections

H5 (Community engagement) Household migration is negatively associated with left behind members engaging in political protest and attending community meetings

Although direct observation of migrants' political roles within their households is not feasible, I test two key observable implications of this logic. First, if migration removes household political spearheads, then migrant households—those currently experiencing out-migration, should be less likely to field a candidate for an official

position in local government. Second, in line with predictions from the political brain drain literature (Goodman and Hiskey 2008; Kapur 2010; Gest 2026), migrants should score higher on political knowledge and external political efficacy—attributes closely linked to political activism—compared to those left behind.

H6a (GP candidacy) Migrant households are less likely to field a candidate in local elections compared to non-migrant households

H6b (Political attributes) Migrants exhibit higher levels of political knowledge and efficacy than left behind individuals

3. India as an empirical case

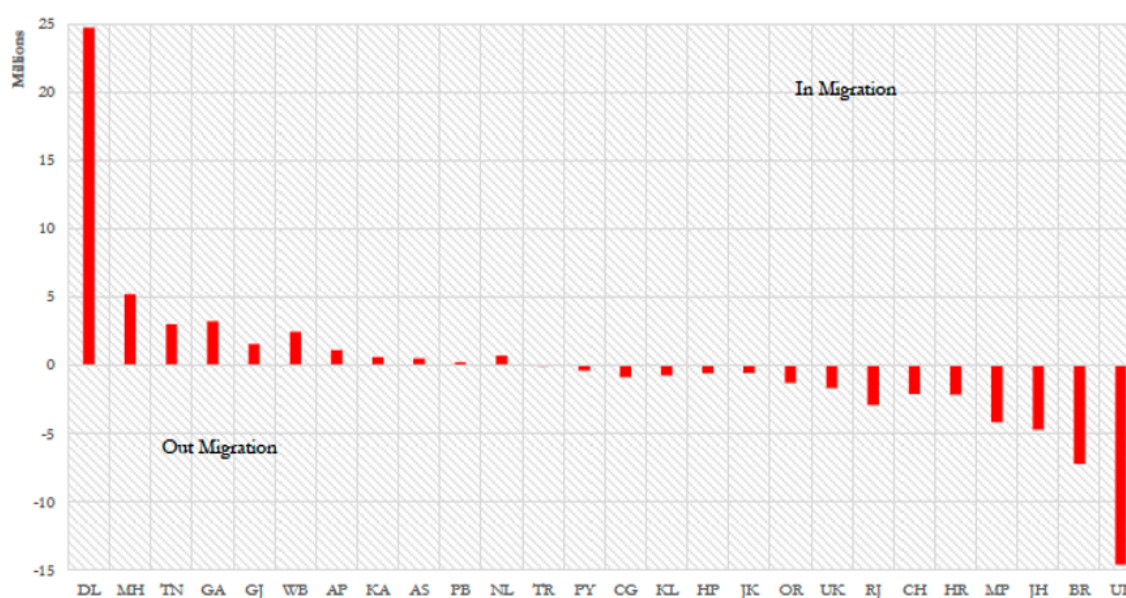
Contemporary India provides an excellent case to examine how migration changes the political economy of sending societies. According to the 2011 Census, India had 450 million internal migrants, accounting for 37% of the country's total population of 1.4 billion. An estimated 100 million of these are estimated to engage in semi-permanent circular work, contributing to 10% of the country's 3.5 trillion-dollar economy (Kim and Nayyar 2018; Deshingkar 2020). Some core industries that employ migrant workers include agriculture, construction, textiles, mines, transportation, street vending, and domestic work (Deshingkar and Akter 2009).

Due to long-running differences in subnational development outcomes, some Indian states have emerged as net recipients of migrant workers, while others have emerged as net exporters. Poorer states such as Uttar Pradesh (U.P.), Bihar, and Jharkhand experience greater out-migration than in-migration, lagging behind wealthier

states such as Maharashtra and Gujarat, which experience greater in-migration than out-migration (Ministry of Finance 2017). Notably, just two states—U.P. and Bihar—collectively account for over a third of all inter-state economic migrant flows (Census of India 2011).

While India remains the top recipient of international remittances, its domestic remittance market is also among largest within the developing world, with estimates ranging from \$36-\$48 billion (Jan Van Duijne 2026). Remittances from domestic migration account for over 30% of household consumption expenditure in rural areas (Ministry of Finance, Government of India, 2017). Regions such as northern Bihar, eastern U.P., and coastal Odisha are particularly exposed to high levels of migration (Tumbe 2016).

Figure 3.1: Average net flows of interstate economic migrants in India, 2011-2016



Source: Economic Survey of India, 2017

Since these movements are predominantly circular, migrants typically maintain strong ties with their left behind families. My survey data reveal that about 95 percent of respondents in migrant households indicated that the migrant would enquire about their health and well-being and check on household finances while being away. About six in 10 respondents (57%) reported that the migrant would advise them on whom to vote for during elections; four in five (84%) mentioned that someone in the household had received advice from the migrant on solving an important problem. A quarter of all respondents (26%) also reported that they engaged in political conversations with the migrant. Long-distance communication occurred with relatively high frequency, with almost 8 in 10 respondents indicating that they would speak to the migrant over the phone at least once or twice a week.

4. Data and empirical strategy

To evaluate my argument, I draw on a range of data collected over 10 months of intensive fieldwork in rural India. My data come from three main sources: the Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS) and its continuing panel, the Socio-Economic Profile of Rural Households in India (SEPRI), an original face-to-face household survey, and focus groups I conducted in a high-migration corridor in eastern India.

4.1 Difference-in-Differences design

The REDS-SEPRI panel is among the few large-scale surveys in India that offer comprehensive demographic and economic data for a nationally representative sample of rural Indian households. The survey provides detailed information on migration and local governance across 12 Indian states. These data were first collected in 1969, with

subsequent rounds in 1970, 1971, 1982, 1999, 2006, and 2014. My empirical analysis employs data from the REDS 2006-08 and SEPRI 2014-16 rounds, as earlier rounds did not collect information on political engagement and local governance. Using these data, I construct a novel two-wave panel spanning 10 years and 12,674 households. This panel design allows me to conduct a Difference-in-Differences (DiD) analysis to examine how changes in migration exposure affect household political engagement. Previous studies have employed a similar approach to examine the political effects of migration on individual-level political behavior in left behind areas (Kumar 2026).

I illustrate the DiD treatment assignment mechanism in Table 4.1. Of the 6,337 non-migrant households originally interviewed in wave 1, 381 switched to migrant status in wave 2.

Table 4.1: Treatment assignment under difference-in-differences

Household migration in Wave 1 (REDS)	Household migration in Wave 2 (SEPRI)	
	No	Yes
No	Control	Treatment

The independent variable in the DiD model is change in household migration, which I code as 1 if a household's migration status changed from non-migrant in wave 1 to migrant in wave 2, and 0 otherwise. I restrict the empirical analysis to non-migrant households in wave 1, which ensures that the treatment captures the effect of a migration onset rather than the effect of continued migration. I estimate the effect of household migration

using the following difference-in-differences specification:

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \text{HHMigration}_i \beta_1 + \text{Time}_t \beta_2 + (\text{HHMigration}_i \times \text{Time}_t) \beta_3 + \mathbf{X}_{it} \gamma + \delta_l + \epsilon_{it}$$

where:

y_{it} is the outcome of interest (claim-making, community meeting attendance) for household i at time t . HHMigration_i is the treatment indicator (1 for households that transitioned from non-migrant to migrant status between waves 1 and 2, 0 otherwise). Time_t is a time dummy (1 for wave 2, 0 otherwise). $\mathbf{X}_{it}$ is a vector of household-level controls, including land ownership, household size, and age and gender of the household head. δ_l denotes state fixed effects. The parameter β_3 represents the Differences-in-Differences (DiD) estimator, which quantifies the differential change in mean outcomes between treated and untreated households. For β_3 to be an unbiased estimator of the causal effect of migration, the parallel trends assumption must be satisfied. This assumption posits that, in the absence of migration, mean outcome trajectories for migrant and non-migrant households would have been identical (Angrist and Pischke 2009).

To assess the plausibility of parallel trends, I construct an additional pre-treatment wave, hereafter referred to as wave 0, using outcome data on retrospective political engagement from REDS 2006. I then merge this data with household data from REDS 1999, which represents the earliest pre-treatment wave for which migration data are

available.⁷ With the inclusion of this additional pre-treatment wave, I estimate a placebo DiD model with the following empirical specification:

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \text{FutureMigration}_i\beta_1 + \text{Time}_t\beta_2 + (\text{FutureMigration}_i \times \text{Time}_t)\beta_3 + \mathbf{X}_{it}\gamma + \delta_1 + \epsilon_{it}$$

where:

y_{it} captures change in political engagement for household i between time t and $t-1$. FutureMigration_i is a binary indicator of future treatment status, taking a value of 1 for future migrant households and 0 otherwise. A future migrant household is defined as one that was non-migrant in waves 0 and 1 but transitioned to migrant status in wave 2. Time_t is a period dummy variable coded 1 for wave 1 and 0 for wave 0, the baseline period. The coefficient β_3 is the placebo Difference-in-Differences (DiD) estimator, which captures the differential change in mean outcomes between future migrant and never-migrant households. Evidence that pre-treatment trends in political engagement are predictive of future migrant status would cast doubt on parallel trends. The absence of such evidence would be reassuring.

The DiD model estimates two primary outcomes—claim-making and community meeting attendance. Claim-making is a binary variable that is coded 1 for any household

⁷ In recent years, scholars have advocated for the implementation of placebo or false experiments to establish the “statistical plausibility” of treatment exogeneity in quasi-experimental designs where randomization is infeasible or ethically problematic (McKenzie and Yang 2022).

that had someone approach an elected representative or government official to seek help with a problem, and 0 otherwise. Community meetings is a continuous variable that captures the mean number of *gram sabha* (village council) meetings attended by each household member. It ranges from 0, indicating that household members attended 0 council meetings on average, to 4, indicating that they attended 4 or more council meetings on average. Since election timing varies across states, I use the two most recent elections at each level as reported in REDS 2006 to construct consistent measures of pre-treatment outcomes spanning the two most recent GP terms.

My research design offers two advantages over cross-sectional observational studies that dominate the existing literature on the political effects of migration. First, repeat observation of the same units over time strengthens the credibility of causal inferences by accounting for unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity (Vidal and Lersch 2021). Estimating the causal effect of migration on political engagement requires that any unobserved determinants of political participation are uncorrelated with migration after conditioning on observables (McKenzie and Yang 2022). Households that send migrants may be systematically different from non-migrant households on characteristics that predict political activism. While some of these attributes—such as economic endowments, geographic location, and ethnicity are readily observable, others, such as risk aversion, migration networks, or institutional push factors are typically unmeasured (McKenzie, Stillman, and Gibson 2010). Failure to account for these selection characteristics can introduce bias, a problem my panel design mitigates by holding time-invariant household characteristics constant.

Second, my empirical strategy enables me to examine pre and post-treatment trends in political outcomes, mitigating concerns that observed differences between migrant and non-migrant households are artifacts of self-selection. All DiD designs rest on the parallel trends assumption—that absent treatment, treated and control households would have had similar outcome trajectories over time. Although this assumption cannot be directly tested, the placebo DiD test of pre-migration trends can bolster our confidence that the associations uncovered in the main DiD model do not reflect baseline political differences.

4.2 Evidence from original survey data

I supplement the difference-in-differences design with original survey data on 1,686 rural households in the eastern Indian state of Bihar. This face-to-face survey provides granular data on household migration particulars, including fine-grained information on remittance transfers and key dimensions of political engagement across a range of civic and political domains. Madhubani, one of the 38 districts that constitute the state of Bihar, is notable among the 17 districts that significantly contribute to internal economic migration in India, collectively accounting for a quarter of all interstate male migration in the country (Bhan et al. 2017). Due to its proximity to rail and road networks, thousands of young and unemployed individuals from Madhubani seek work in some of India's largest cities, including Delhi and Mumbai. Many secure work at urban construction sites and textile factories, but also in service industries such as hospitality, private security, and transportation. A small but notable fraction of migrants also migrate seasonally to northern Indian states of Punjab and Haryana, where demand for low-cost migrant labor spikes during sowing and transplanting seasons. International migration

is relatively rare in this region, although cross-border migration to Gulf countries is not uncommon.

My household survey employs a three-stage probability sampling design. First, I randomly sampled 17 of the 21 blocks or sub-divisions that make up Madhubani district. Second, within each block, I randomly sampled six Gram Panchayats (GPs), or village councils, which embody the lowest tier of government in India's federal democracy.⁸ Finally, within each GP, I employed stratified random sampling to select 20 households for face-to-face interviews. Enumerators were assigned to interview every 10th household within the sampled GPs, starting with the local *anganwadi*, or state-run childcare centre. The survey protocol required enumerators to skip 10 households after each dwelling they approached, regardless of whether they were able to conduct an interview in it.⁹ Within each GP, households were stratified based on self-reported exposure to migration in the past 5 years. Given the exceptionally high migration rates across this region, it was

⁸ A typical administrative block in Bihar consists of 20 GPs.

⁹ Interviews were unsuccessful due to a variety of reasons, including locked household premises, the absent adult household members, explicit refusals, or enumerators having already met their daily interview quotas for migrant households. Notably, the survey had exceptionally low refusal rates, with approximately 2% of the contacted households declining participation despite the absence of monetary incentives.

necessary to oversample non-migrant households.¹⁰

Migration patterns in India exhibit a notable ethnic selectivity, with certain ethnic groups engaging in migration at higher rates than others. Micro-studies suggest that migration of the short-term circular kind is more prevalent among socially marginalized groups, such as Scheduled Caste (SC), Scheduled Tribe (ST), and lower Other Backward Class (OBC) communities, compared to socially privileged upper caste groups (Gidwani and Sivaramakrishnan 2003; Deshingkar and Akter 2009). However, recent studies contest this claim, indicating that this pattern is characteristic of seasonal migration rather than long-term semi-permanent migration that tends to be dominated by upper caste groups (Chandrasekhar and Mitra 2019). This paper focuses specifically on the political effects of the latter.

¹⁰ In rural areas of north Bihar, eastern Uttar Pradesh, and coastal Odisha, studies note that between 30 and 70 percent of households have at least one family member migrating for work to another Indian states (Kim and Nayyar 2018).

Figure 4.2: A survey interview in progress



Source: Author's fieldwork

The selection characteristics of economic migration in India render standard probability sampling techniques inadequate for obtaining representative samples of migrant households. To mitigate this problem, I had a mapping team sketch out ethnic maps for each sampled GP in Madhubani. These maps provide fine-grained insights into the distribution of ethnic groups within each GP. By consolidating GP wards inhabited by similar ethnic groups, I identified ethnically homogeneous clusters within each GP, with each cluster comprising four to five wards. As Table A-2 in the Appendix reveals, the survey is broadly representative of the major ethnic groups in the state, including SC, OBC, Muslim, and Hindu upper caste groups.

The main independent variable in the survey analysis is household migration, coded as 1 if any member of the household was actively migrating for work within India—defined as having spent at least six months away from home in another district or state for economic reasons in the past 5 years, and 0 otherwise. I drop returnee households from the analysis as my argument concerns the political effects of migrant absence rather than the long-term impact of returnees, whose presence may potentially restore the household’s political equilibrium.

I examine two distinct clusters of dependent variables that capture electoral as well as non-electoral dimensions of household political engagement. The first cluster of outcomes taps into formal political participation in activities like voting and campaigning, and council candidacies. For voting, I look at self-reported turnout in the most recent local, state, and national elections.¹¹ ‘Electoral turnout’ ranges from 0 to 3, with 0 indicating that the individual respondent voted in none of the three elections, to 3, indicating that they voted in all three. Next, I look at household campaign participation in the most recent GP elections. The variable ‘GP campaign’ likewise ranges from 0 to 3, with 0 indicating that nobody in the household participated in any of the three campaign activities—election meetings, political rallies, or door-to-door canvassing—to 3, indicating participation in all three. Last, I examine whether a household fielded a candidate for an official position in the most recent GP elections. ‘GP candidate’ equals 1 if a household fielded a candidate for an official position—ward member or council

¹¹ The most recent local GP elections before the survey were held in 2021. National elections were held in 2019, a year before Covid-19 snowballed into a global pandemic.

president—in the most recent village council elections, 0 otherwise.

The second cluster of dependent variables taps into non-electoral, resource-intensive dimensions of political activism, such as engagement in political protest and participation in community meetings. I measure protest participation using responses to the following survey question:

Here is a list of actions that people sometimes take to draw the attention of local authorities to the demands and grievances of the public. In the past 3 years, have you or someone from your household participated in a protest, demonstration, or *gherao* (encirclement)?

‘Political protest’ is coded as 1 if anyone in the household participated in a protest or public demonstration in the past 3 years, and 0 otherwise. ‘Community meetings’ is a binary variable that takes in 1 for any household that had someone attend a community meeting in the last 3 years, and 0 otherwise. To analyze these data, I use OLS to estimate linear probability models with the following empirical specification:

$$y_{ik} = \alpha + \text{HHMigration}_{ik}\beta_1 + \text{Individual}_{ik}\beta_2 + \text{Household}_{ik}\beta_3 + \text{InterviewerFE}_j\gamma_j + \text{GPFE}_k\delta_k + e_{ik}$$

where:

y_{ik} is the outcome of interest for household_{*i*} in GP_{*k*}, estimated separately for each of the four outcomes. HHMigration_{*i*} is a binary indicator of active household migration status. Individual_{*ik*} is a vector of individual-level controls, including age, gender,

educational attainment, and government employment. Household_{ik} is a vector of household-level controls, including household size, land ownership, asset base, caste, religion, crime victimization, and disaster exposure. InterviewerFE_j denotes interviewer fixed effects. GPFE_k absorbs unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity in institutional quality and economic development within a village council. I cluster standard errors at the village council level to account for within-GP correlation in outcomes.

5. Results

Results from the main difference-in-differences model appear in tables 5.1 and 5.2. These models test H1 and H2 by estimating the differential rate of change in political engagement across households that switched from non-migrant to migrant status between the two waves of the panel, and those that did not. Column (1) displays results from the base specification, column (2) includes controls for key time-varying confounders like changes in household size, land ownership, and age and gender of the household head, and column (3) presents the specification with state fixed effects.

The effect of migration on political engagement is striking: The negative coefficient on $\text{HH Migration} \times \text{Time}$, the DiD estimator, indicates that households that transitioned from non-migrant to migrant status between waves 1 and 2 saw claim-making rates decline by almost 7 percentage points, compared to non-migrant households. This effect is statistically significant at the 99% confidence level ($p < 0.01$). The coefficient attenuates slightly when time-varying controls and state fixed effects are introduced, but remains

significant at conventional thresholds ($p < 0.01$).¹²

Table 5.1: DiD estimates of the effect of migration on claim-making among left behind households

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Household migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.046** (0.008)	0.052** (0.008)	0.059** (0.009)
Time (1=Wave 2, 0=Wave 1)	-0.732** (0.006)	-0.729** (0.006)	-0.733** (0.006)
Household migration x Time	-0.069** (0.022)	-0.063** (0.022)	-0.067** (0.022)
HH size		0.004** (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
HH land ownership		0.007** (0.001)	0.004** (0.001)
HH head age		-0.003** (0.000)	-0.002** (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.043** (0.010)	0.052** (0.010)
Observations	12674	12654	12654
Adjusted R ²	0.552	0.560	0.584
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.936	0.936	0.936

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

Robust standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses.

¹² The overall decline in outcome measures across waves reflects differences in measurement rather than genuine changes in political behavior. Wave 1 measures of claim-making and community meeting attendance capture political activities undertaken over the entire current village council term, while wave 2 restricts the recall period to the last 12 months. Since wave 1 covers a longer reference period, households naturally report a higher incidence of civic and political engagement. Importantly, this measurement difference affects both treated and control households equally, and differences out in the DiD estimator, leaving the identification of the treatment effect unaffected.

The results for community engagement are in the expected direction and consistent with H2. Households that shifted status from non-migrant to migrant during the panel experienced a significant drop in community meeting attendance than households that did not. Substantively, migrant households saw average attendance per member decline by 0.23 meetings, relative to non-migrant households over the same period ($p < 0.05$). This effect is also robust to the inclusion of time-varying confounders and state fixed effects.

Table 5.2: DiD estimates of the effect of migration on community meeting attendance among left behind households

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Household migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.186† (0.103)	0.184† (0.102)	0.205* (0.091)
Time (1=Wave 2, 0=Wave 1)	-1.525** (0.024)	-1.540** (0.024)	-1.474** (0.024)
Household migration x Time	-0.230* (0.109)	-0.216* (0.108)	-0.217* (0.102)
HH size		-0.017** (0.004)	-0.014** (0.004)
HH land ownership		-0.001 (0.002)	-0.005† (0.003)
HH head age		-0.006** (0.001)	-0.005** (0.001)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.115** (0.028)	0.076** (0.029)
Observations	9898	9878	9878
Adjusted R ²	0.406	0.413	0.479
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	1.822	1.822	1.822

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

Robust standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses.

Table 5.3 presents placebo DiD estimates comparing future and never-migrant households on my primary outcomes—claim-making and community meeting

attendance. These models test for whether political differences between the two groups predate migration. The placebo DiD coefficients for claim-making are negligible in magnitude across all specifications, and none approach conventional significance thresholds. The base specification for community meetings yields a positive interaction term, suggesting that future migrant households were if anything, more politically active than non-migrant households before migration—a pre-trend that runs counter to the direction of the main DiD estimate.

I also check the robustness of my placebo DiD models using a range of secondary outcomes capturing household participation in local and national elections. These results are reported in tables A-3-A-7 in the Appendix. I find no evidence of pre-treatment political differences across any of these outcomes. Taken together, these results indicate that future migrant and never-migrant households were trending similarly across key dimensions of political engagement before the onset of migration, and are consistent with the parallel trends assumption underlying the main DiD analysis.¹³

¹³ The placebo DiD model is based on a reduced sample as a non-trivial subset of non-migrant households in wave 1 had economic migrants in wave 0, rendering them unsuitable as a control group. For community meetings, some data are missing due to attrition.

Table 5.3: Placebo DiD estimates of pre-treatment trends

	Claim-making		Community meetings	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.005** (0.002)	0.004* (0.002)	-0.213 (0.195)	-0.202 (0.200)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.005)	-0.562** (0.043)	-0.558** (0.172)
Future migration x Time	-0.001 (0.002)	0.000 (0.002)	0.343† (0.183)	0.287 (0.235)
HH size		0.001† (0.000)		-0.011 (0.011)
HH land ownership		-0.000† (0.000)		0.001 (0.005)
HH head age		-0.000 (0.000)		-0.001 (0.003)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.001 (0.006)		-0.046 (0.154)
Observations	5728	4046	2837	1854
Adjusted R ²	-0.000	0.003	0.033	0.241
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	Yes	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.995	0.995	2.506	2.506

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses.

Note: Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2. Wave 0 outcomes are retrospective measures of household political engagement from REDS 2006 corresponding to the previous village council term.

In Figure 5.1, I plot coefficients from OLS models testing **H4** and **H5**.¹⁴ These models compare cross-sectional differences in political engagement between migrant and non-migrant households. The results for formal politics are unambiguous: Household migration is associated with significant reductions across both dimensions of formal political engagement. Members of migrant households turn out at significantly lower rates across local, state, and national elections ($p < 0.01$) and are significantly less likely to engage in campaign activities during local elections ($p < 0.01$) In the full specification—

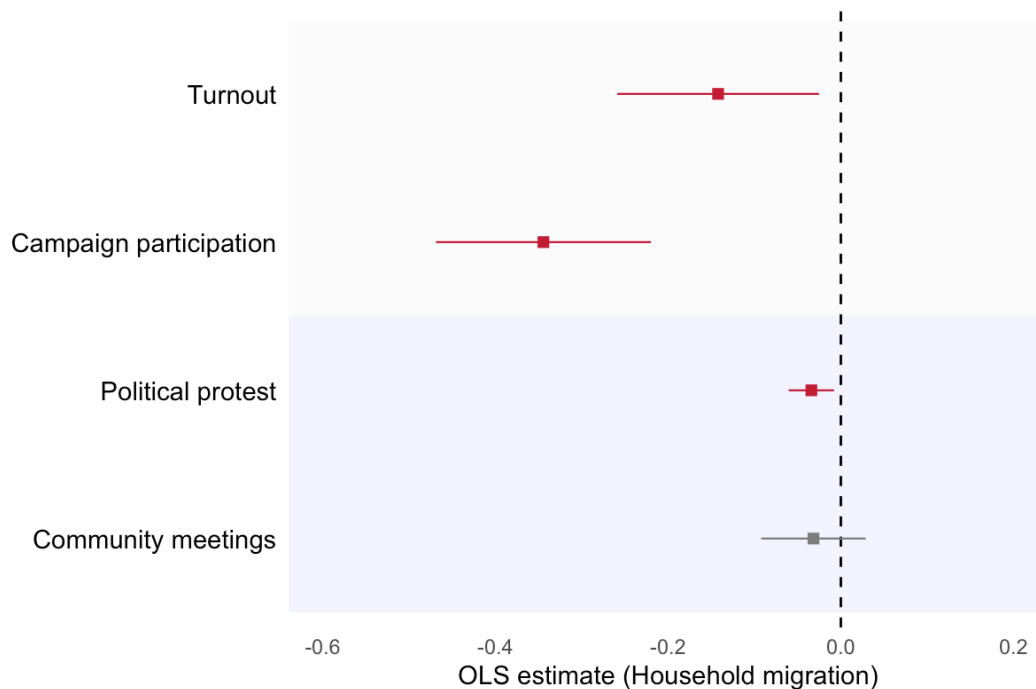
¹⁴ The full model specifications are reported in Tables A-8 and A-9 in the Appendix.

which includes individual and household controls alongside council and interviewer fixed effects—migration is associated with participation in 0.2 fewer elections out of 3 (approximately 7.5% relative to the average individual in a non-migrant household), and 0.31 fewer campaign activities (roughly 28% relative to the non-migrant baseline).

The effect on protest participation is statistically significant across all specifications ($p < 0.05$). Being a left behind member is associated with a roughly 4-percentage point decline in the probability of engaging in contentious political acts, a 40% reduction relative to the non-migrant mean. Migration incidence is also negatively associated with community meeting attendance, but only in the base specification. Migrant households attend community meetings at rates 6-percentage points lower than non-migrant households, corresponding to a 28% reduction relative to the non-migrant mean. However, the coefficient loses statistical significance once controls and interviewer and GP fixed effects are added.

This null result suggests that meetings may be less sensitive to migration-induced compositional shifts than other forms of political engagement—perhaps because left behind members continue to attend in the absence of the migrant. While this is the one outcome measure for which I don't find significant evidence of demobilization, the overall direction of this test is clear and consistent with the DiD results on a different dataset from a different region and different time period.

Figure 5.1: OLS estimates of the effect of migration on political engagement among left behind households



Note: Estimates from OLS models with household and individual-level controls, GP fixed effects, and interviewer fixed effects. Turnout is measured at the individual level. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. N=1,416.

Collectively, my cross-sectional findings reveal an intriguing pattern. Migration has the largest relative effects on campaign participation and contentious political activism—the more resource-intensive forms of political engagement that require time, money, and community membership beyond the simple act of turning out to vote. Yet, these findings also beg an important question: What explains the broad-based disengagement effect of migration among left behind households?

5.4 Mechanisms of disengagement

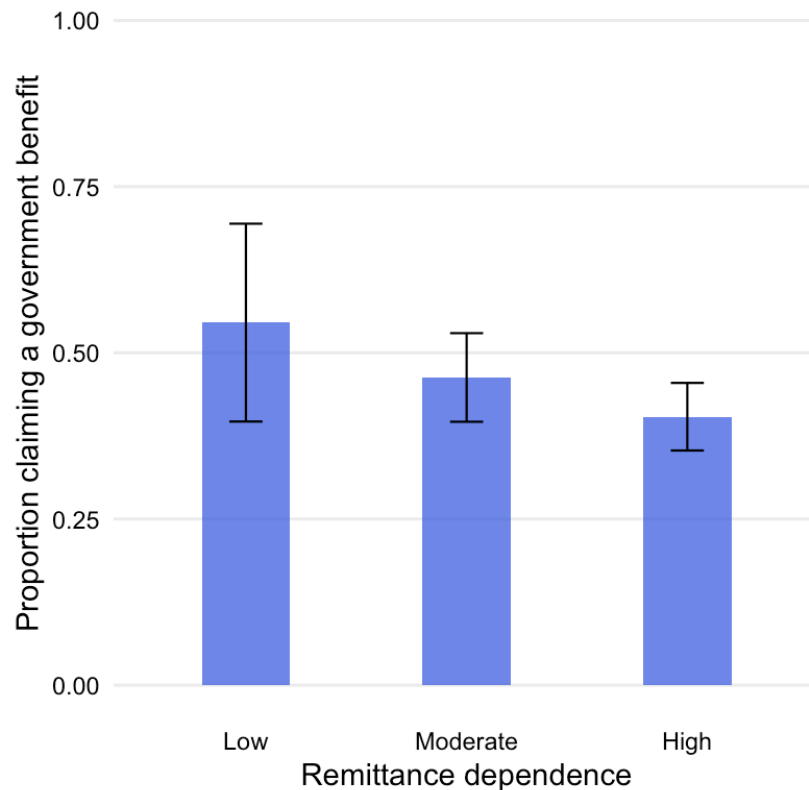
One potential explanation for the observed effect lies in the substitution effect of migrant remittances discussed in the literature—by easing financial hardship and lowering material insecurities, remittances can reduce the need for households to demand welfare support from the state. If remittances indeed function as a form of informal insurance, the marginal incentive to seek welfare benefits should diminish as remittance transfers increase. In other words, migrant households receiving larger transfers should claim government benefits at lower rates than households receiving smaller transfers (**H3**).

In figure 5.2, I plot the bivariate relationship between remittance dependence and benefit-claiming.¹⁵ The bar plot reveals a clear pattern: roughly 54% households with low dependence on remittances claimed a government benefit in the past 3 years, compared to 40% of households with high remittance dependence—a difference of 14-percentage points. One limitation of this measure is that it captures subjective dependence rather than an objective measure of economic support. It is plausible, for instance, for a household with low perceived dependence to receive large transfers in absolute terms. Another concern is that remittances may make households ineligible for state benefits if they cross certain income thresholds, in which case the observed association between remittances and claim-making could reflect eligibility constraints rather than a

¹⁵ I measure remittance dependence using responses to the following survey item: To what extent do the total expenses of your household depend on money remitted by the migrant? Is it a lot, some, very little, or not at all? Values range from 1 to 3, with 1 indicating little or no dependence, and 3 indicating high dependence.

substitution of public benefits with private transfers.

Figure 5.2: Bivariate relationship between remittance dependence and benefit-claiming within migrant households



Note: Sample restricted to migrant households (N=680). Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

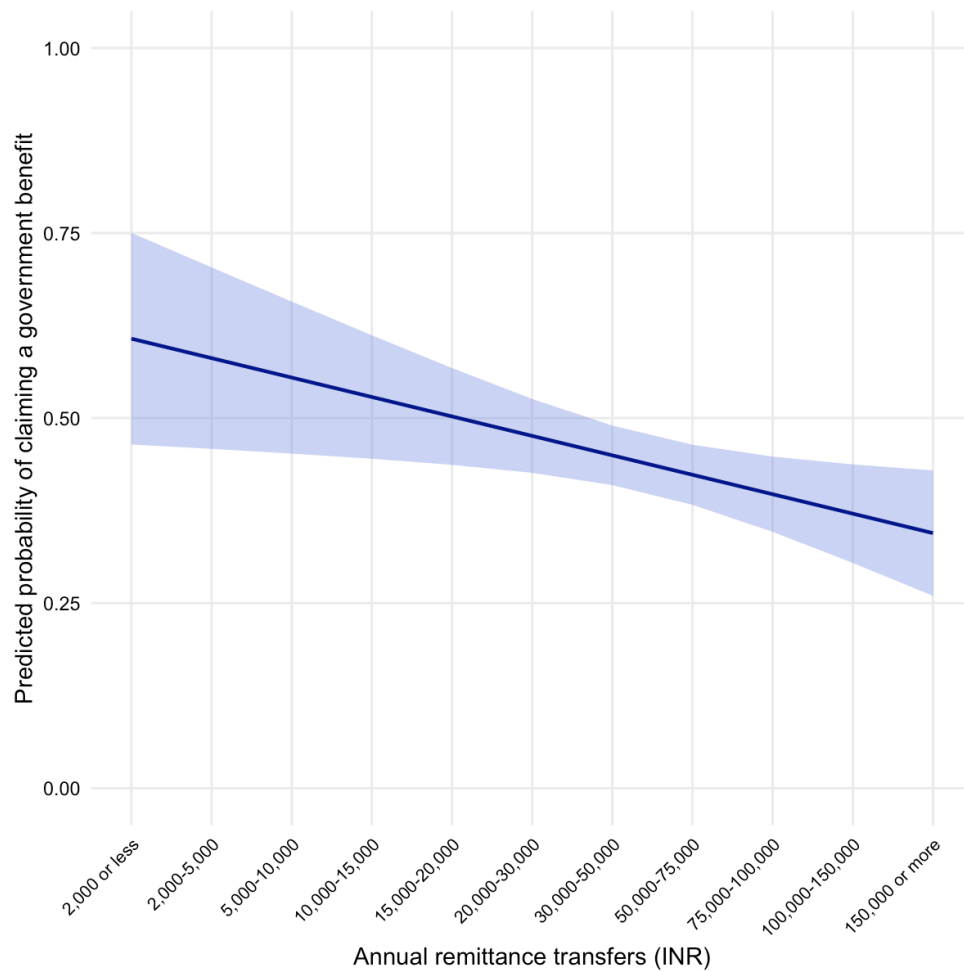
To evaluate the substitution mechanism more precisely, I use original survey data on remittance transfers to construct 'annual remittance transfer', a categorical variable ranging from 1 to 11, where higher values indicate larger remittance transfers received by a household¹⁶. The median remittance received by migrant households in the sample

¹⁶ I measure this using responses to the following question: On average, how much money is the migrant able to send in 1 year?

falls in the 50,000-75,000 rupee range (approximately 600 to 900 US dollars). I measure benefit-claiming using a survey question that asked whether anyone in the household contacted an elected representative or government official to secure a benefit under a state-run welfare program—such as old age pension or housing support scheme—within the past 3 years. Since this measure captures attempted access to government support rather than actual benefit receipt, it's a purer measure of political effort that is less likely to be contaminated by drivers of success like eligibility criteria or partisan connections.

Figure 5.3 plots predicted probabilities of benefit-claiming derived from a linear probability model that estimates the marginal effect of remittance transfers on benefit-claiming incidence, controlling for individual and household characteristics (See table A-10 in the Appendix). The results provide suggestive evidence in support of **H3**: benefit-claiming declines progressively as remittance transfers increase ($p < 0.05$), falling from roughly 58% among households receiving Rs. 2,000 or less to 38% among those receiving 100,000 rupees or more—a drop of nearly 20 percentage points. The coefficient on 'annual remittance' remains stable and statistically significant in the full specification with controls, suggesting that the effect is not driven by omitted variables like socioeconomic status or changes in household composition.

Figure 5.3: Predicted probability of benefit-claiming within remittance receiving migrant households



Note: Predictions from OLS with individual and household-level controls. Sample restricted to migrant households (N=680). Controls are set at sample means.

My theoretical argument anticipates that migration will also contribute to political withdrawal in left behind areas by selectively removing households' most politically active members—their political spearheads. If the political brain drain mechanism is at work, two observable implications follow. First, left behind households should be less likely to field candidates for official positions in local government, as the departure of the more politically active members depletes the household's stock of political entrepreneurs (H6a). Second, if migrants are indeed household political spearheads, they should be

positively selected on attributes that predict political activism (**H6b**).

I look at two such attributes—political knowledge and political efficacy, both well-documented predictors of political participation in the literature (Campbell, Gurin, and Miller 1954; Verba, Schlozman, and Brady 1995; Delli Karpini and Keeter 1996). The variable ‘political knowledge’ taps into an individual’s awareness of social rights and captures the extent to which an individual is informed about citizen entitlements under flagship government programs (Weitz-Shapiro and Winters 2023). ‘Political efficacy’, on the other hand, taps into the belief that one’s individual political actions can meaningfully impact the political process. If migrants are household political spearheads, they should score higher on both these attributes relative to those left behind.

Table 5.4 presents results from multivariate OLS models comparing council candidacy rates between migrant and non-migrant households. The results indicate that left behind households are significantly less likely to field a candidate for an official position in the village council compared to their non-migrant counterparts ($p < 0.01$). Substantively, household migration is associated with a nearly 6 percentage-point drop in the probability of a household fielding a candidate in local elections—a 33% relative decline to the non-migrant mean.

This finding is consistent with H6a, which predicts that migration strips households of their political spearheads, lowering the likelihood that left behind members will enter local politics. Documentary evidence lends credence to this interpretation. Newspaper reports from the 2021 village council elections reveal that over 2,000 economic migrants ran for thousands of posts in 806 rural local government bodies

in the high-migration *Seemanchal* region of northern Bihar, suggesting that migrants constitute a non-trivial share of the local candidate pool.¹⁷ These results suggest that migrant households are deprived of precisely the same individuals whose resources and political attributes enable them to contest elections and participate in local civic and political life.

Table 5.4: OLS estimates of differences in council candidacy rates between migrant and non-migrant households

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Household migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	-0.093** (0.019)	-0.059** (0.022)	-0.059** (0.022)
Observations	1417	1416	1416
Adjusted R ²	0.012	0.086	0.091
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
GP Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Interviewer Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

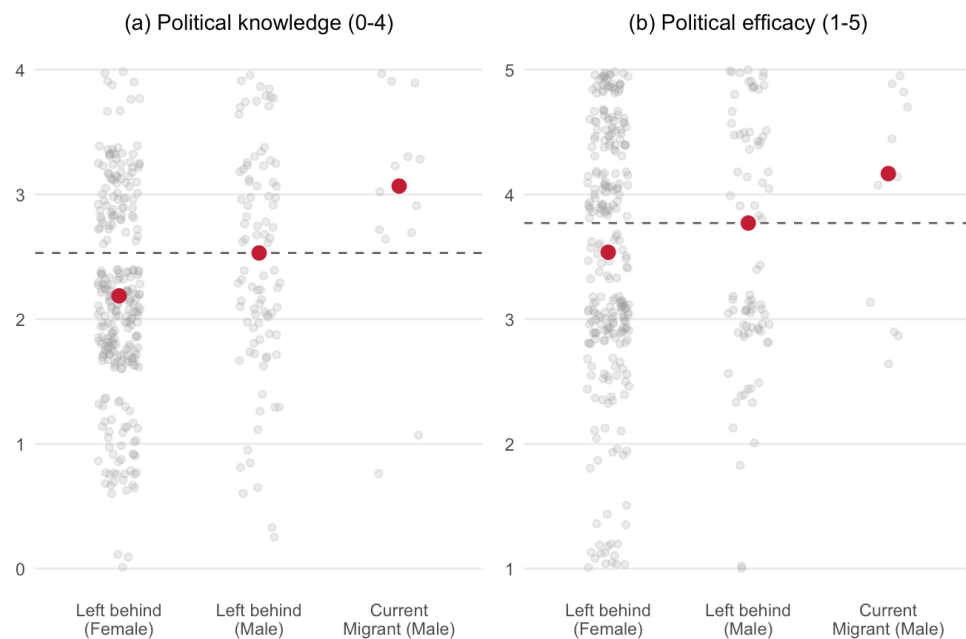
CR2 cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the village council level.

Since migrants in the survey are almost exclusively male, any observed differences in attributes could be driven by gender rather than political orientation. To address this, figure 5.4 plots the group means for male migrants alongside those for left behind male and female respondents for both political attributes.

¹⁷ Jha, Aditya Nath. 2021. "Migrants outbound again, after a shot at panchayat posts."

Hindustan Times. November 18.

Figure 5.4: Mean political knowledge and external efficacy among migrants and left behind individuals, by gender



Note: Red dots indicate group means. Sample restricted to current migrants and left behind individuals in active migrant households (N=403).

Given the small number of migrants in the sample (N=15), this analysis is the most suggestive in the paper and therefore these results should be interpreted with caution.¹⁸ Two patterns stand out. First, migrants exhibit higher levels of political knowledge than left behind individuals. Male migrants provide correct answers to 3 of the 4 political knowledge questions on average, compared to 2.5 among left behind males and 2.19 among left behind females. Second, male migrants are the most politically efficacious among all groups (4.17/5), followed by left behind males (3.77/5) and left behind females (3.54/5). Whether these differences reflect pre-migration attitudes or beliefs acquired at

¹⁸These observations represent the few instances in which the survey actually interviewed the migrant themselves.

migration destinations cannot be established from cross-sectional data, and I leave this question for future research.

6. Discussion and Implications

In many developing countries, circular economic migration remains central to how households manage risk and respond to economic uncertainty. The scarcity of non-farm livelihood options in rural areas coupled with the high cost of living in urban destinations makes circulation a rational strategy. Yet, the political effects of this important form of migration for out-migration areas remain relatively understudied. In this paper, I develop and test an argument about why migration fosters political disengagement in left behind regions. Using a difference-in-differences design that compares households before and after the onset of migration, I demonstrate that migration is associated with robust and significant reductions in political engagement in left behind places: households that transition from non-migrant to migrant status during the panel approach elected officials for assistance at lower rates and attend community meetings less often than households that don't. I extend and corroborate these findings using original survey data from a high-migration corridor in eastern India, showing that members of left behind households are systematically less likely to vote, campaign, protest, and contest local elections compared to members of non-migrant households.

Collectively, my findings suggest that migration is not just an economic phenomenon but also a political one with implications for democratic governance in places left behind by economic globalization. When households gain access to exit options such as migration, local politicians face may have fewer incentives to invest in public services. As previous work on this question shows, migration enables

governments to outsource their welfare obligations to diaspora networks and deflect demands for far-reaching institutional and policy reform (Goodman and Hiskey 2008; Germano 2018; Sellars 2019).

My findings also speak to recent work on migrant selection and geographic sorting, underscoring the importance of ‘who migrates’ for understanding the downstream political effects of migration (Lim 2023; Dancygier et al. 2025). In contexts with poor development outcomes, broad-based civic and political engagement is one of the few ways in which citizens can hold governments accountable for effective service delivery. When citizens most likely to drive this engagement process leave, local governments may face fewer pressures to perform. In the long-run, the cumulative effect of these changes could lead to the hollowing out of grass-roots public institutions, locking left behind areas into development traps (Bénassy and Brezis 2013; Chami et al. 2018). Relatedly, much prior work on internal migration and democracy has tended to focus on conflict between migrants and natives in destination areas (Bhavnani and Lacina 2015; Kramon et al. 2022), but my research underscores an equally significant political consequence of migration in origin areas—the erosion of everyday accountability pressures that are crucial for ensuring basic service delivery in low- and middle-income countries.

Finally, my work also underscores the need to distinguish between internal and international migration when evaluating the political consequences of emigration in left behind areas. The prevailing optimism surrounding migrants as conduits of democratization and cosmopolitanism is largely based on the idea of “social

remittances”, which suggests that migrants return with new ideas and expectations about citizenship and governance (Levitt 1998; Kapur 2014; Córdova and Hiskey 2015; Barsbai et al. 2017; Gaikwad, Hanson, and Tóth 2024). However, this mechanism assumes that migrants are exposed to better institutions abroad and have positive interactions with host societies. In the case of India, as in other emerging economies where migration is mainly internal and directed towards low-wage, precarious work that exposes migrants to new forms of structural violence and political exclusion (Thachil 2020; Gaikwad and Nellis 2021), such exposure is, at best, minimal. Consequently, the expected benefits of political diffusion are largely absent while the risk of disengagement looms large.

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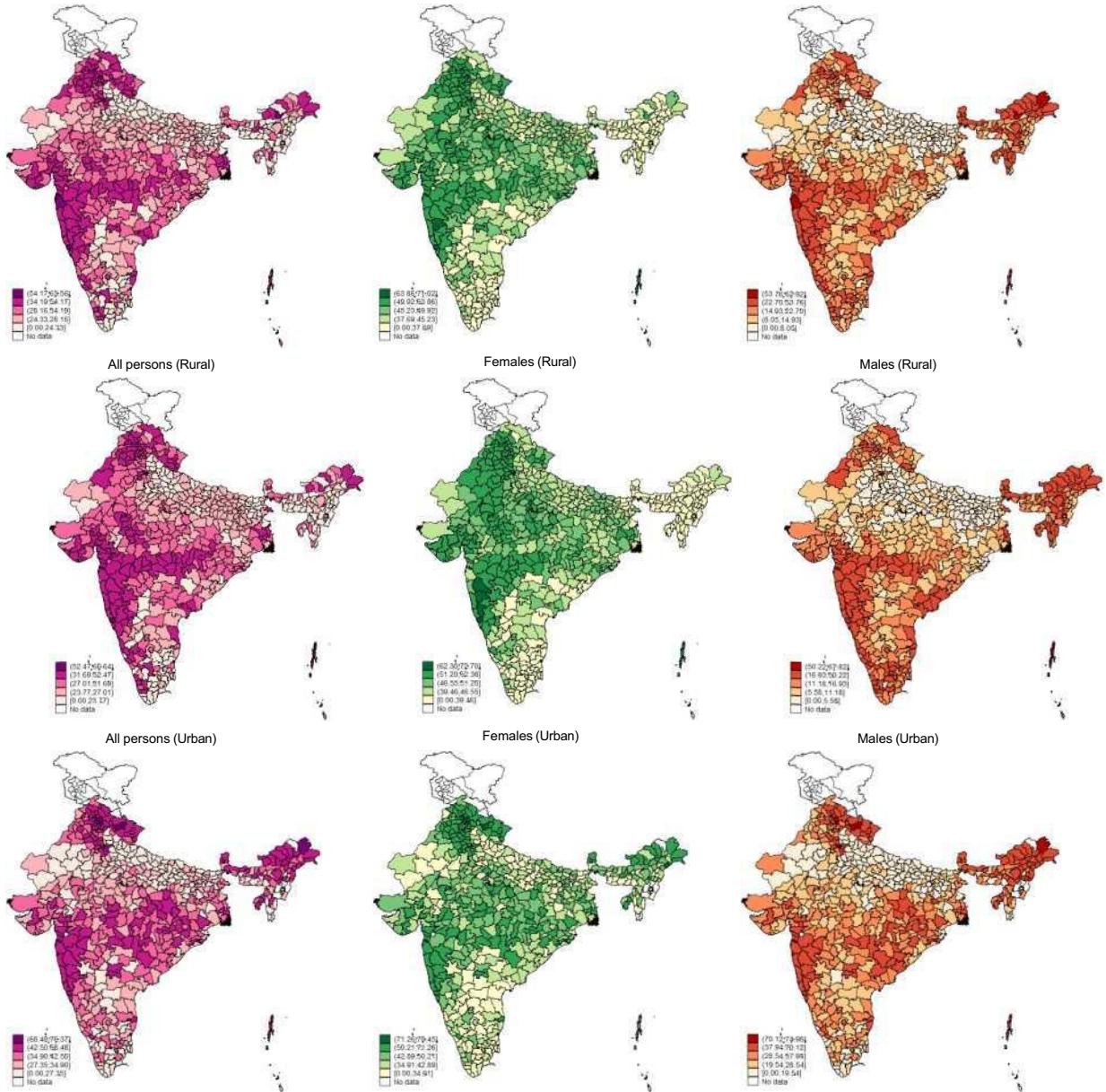
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Appendix

Figure A-1: District-wise migration rates (in percent), Census of India 2001



Note: The map illustrates the aggregate migration rate, which was defined as the ratio of the people whose birthplace was not the place of enumeration to the total population in the district. The value ranges correspond to 25th percentile, 50th percentile, 75th percentile and 99th percentile. There is no data for districts of Jammu and Kashmir.

Table A-1: Summary statistics of key variables across datasets

Variable	Mean	Standard Deviation	Min	Max	N
REDS					
Household migration	0.00	0.00	0	0	6337
Claim-making	0.94	0.24	0	1	6337
Community meetings	1.83	1.28	0	4	3561
Household size	5.68	2.78	1	45	6337
Land ownership	1.40	3.37	0	62.5	6337
Scheduled Caste	0.12	0.32	0	1	6337
Scheduled Tribe	0.08	0.27	0	1	6337
Other Backward Class	0.41	0.49	0	1	6337
Muslim	0.15	0.36	0	1	6337
SEPRI					
Household migration	0.06	0.24	0	1	6337
Claim-making	0.20	0.40	0	1	6337
Community meetings	0.30	0.58	0	4	6337
Household size	4.48	2.33	1	22	6337
Land ownership	1.69	3.34	0	53	6337
Scheduled Caste	0.19	0.40	0	1	6336
Scheduled Tribe	0.10	0.29	0	1	6336
Other Backward Class	0.44	0.50	0	1	6336
Muslim	0.15	0.36	0	1	6336
Madhubani Migration Survey					
Household migration	0.30	0.46	0	1	1433
Turnout	2.60	0.87	0	3	1433
GP campaign	1.03	1.18	0	3	1433
GP candidate	0.15	0.36	0	1	1433
Protest participation	0.09	0.28	0	1	1433
Community meetings	0.27	0.44	0	1	1433
Government benefit	0.43	0.50	0	1	1433

Table A-2: Profile of sampled households in Madhubani Migration Survey, 2023

Social groups	Sample profile (%)	Target population profile (%)
Other Backward Class (O.B.C.)	53.02	50.37
General	12.16	10.60
Muslim	15.84	17.70
Rural	100.00	89.70
Women	0.52	47.86
N	1686	

Note: The overrepresentation of women and underrepresentation of urban residents is consistent with established patterns of economic migration in the state, and I do not anticipate these minor imbalances to significantly bias my results.

[illegible]

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Table A-3: Placebo DiD estimates for GP election turnout

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	-0.025 (0.042)	-0.077 (0.048)	-0.035 (0.031)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	-0.011 (0.009)	-0.194** (0.035)	-0.013 (0.022)
Future migration x Time	0.009 (0.036)	0.053 (0.040)	0.052 (0.032)
HH size		0.022** (0.002)	0.006** (0.002)
HH land ownership		-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)
HH head age		-0.004** (0.001)	-0.001* (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.076* (0.032)	0.020 (0.022)
Observations	5723	5362	4045
Adjusted R ²	-0.000	0.026	0.585
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.71	0.71	0.71

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2.

Table A-4: Placebo DiD estimates for state election turnout

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.005 (0.025)	0.009 (0.023)	0.006 (0.024)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	0.008 (0.007)	-0.028 (0.019)	-0.005 (0.020)
Future migration x Time	0.005 (0.022)	0.001 (0.023)	0.003 (0.022)
HH size		0.004** (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
HH land ownership		0.001† (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
HH head age		-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.066** (0.022)	0.034 (0.024)
Observations	5723	5362	4045
Adjusted R ²	-0.000	0.006	0.037
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.917	0.917	0.917

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2.

Table A-5: Placebo DiD estimates for national election turnout

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	-0.006 (0.025)	0.017 (0.019)	0.014 (0.020)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	-0.009 (0.006)	-0.057** (0.017)	-0.029 (0.018)
Future migration x Time	0.012 (0.023)	-0.011 (0.020)	-0.020 (0.020)
HH size		0.005** (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)
HH land ownership		0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
HH head age		-0.001* (0.000)	-0.001 (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.077** (0.023)	0.020 (0.023)
Observations	5723	5362	4045
Adjusted R ²	-0.000	0.011	0.036
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.927	0.927	0.927

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2.

Table A-6: Placebo DiD estimates for GP Pradhan (council president) candidacy

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.003 (0.008)	0.006 (0.010)	0.007 (0.010)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.009* (0.005)	-0.009† (0.005)
Future migration x Time	-0.005 (0.008)	-0.009 (0.010)	-0.011 (0.010)
HH size		0.001* (0.000)	0.001* (0.001)
HH land ownership		0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
HH head age		-0.000* (0.000)	-0.000* (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		-0.003 (0.004)	-0.004 (0.006)
Observations	5723	5362	4045
Adjusted R ²	0.000	0.002	0.002
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.005	0.005	0.005

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2.

Table A-7: Placebo DiD estimates for GP member candidacy

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Future migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.002 (0.011)	0.006 (0.014)	0.007 (0.014)
Time (1=Wave 1, 0=Wave 0)	0.000 (0.003)	0.015† (0.009)	0.017† (0.010)
Future migration x Time	0.004 (0.012)	0.000 (0.014)	0.001 (0.015)
HH size		0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
HH land ownership		0.001 (0.000)	0.001 (0.000)
HH head age		0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
HH head gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.010* (0.004)	0.009 (0.006)
Observations	5723	5362	4045
Adjusted R ²	-0.000	0.002	0.003
Time-Varying Controls	No	Yes	Yes
State Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Dependent Variable Mean	0.014	0.014	0.014

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. Future Migration indicates non-migrant households in waves 0 and 1 that transitioned to migrant status in wave 2.

Table A-8: OLS estimates of the effect of migration on formal political engagement among left behind households

	Electoral turnout			Campaign participation		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Household migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	-0.197** (0.060)	-0.128* (0.059)	-0.142* (0.060)	-0.190** (0.068)	-0.296** (0.064)	-0.345** (0.063)
Scheduled Caste (1=S.C., 0=General)		0.085 (0.082)	0.080 (0.085)		0.364** (0.116)	0.378** (0.126)
Other Backward Class (1=O.B.C., 0=General)		0.059 (0.060)	0.050 (0.072)		0.210* (0.093)	0.229* (0.109)
Muslim (1=Muslim, 0=General)		0.076 (0.075)	0.076 (0.077)		0.338** (0.111)	0.196 (0.129)
Land ownership		0.009 (0.011)	0.001 (0.011)		0.011 (0.021)	0.023 (0.022)
Asset index		0.023† (0.014)	0.026† (0.015)		0.082** (0.023)	0.065** (0.023)
Household size (1-9)		0.044** (0.011)	0.043** (0.011)		0.035* (0.018)	0.044* (0.018)
Disaster exposure (0=Very low, 3=Very high)		-0.007 (0.014)	0.005 (0.016)		0.077** (0.023)	0.046* (0.023)
Crime victimization (1=Yes, 0=No)		-0.136 (0.094)	-0.145 (0.100)		0.108 (0.119)	0.137 (0.119)
Age (18-85)		0.020** (0.002)	0.020** (0.002)		-0.001 (0.003)	-0.000 (0.002)
Gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.089† (0.049)	0.091† (0.053)		-0.147† (0.081)	-0.190* (0.080)
Education (1=Non-literate, 8=Graduate & above)		-0.053** (0.010)	-0.052** (0.011)		-0.044** (0.017)	-0.042* (0.017)
Government job (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.377** (0.068)	0.401** (0.076)		-0.115 (0.131)	-0.232† (0.139)
Observations	1417	1416	1416	1417	1416	1416
Adjusted R ²	0.010	0.160	0.170	0.004	0.036	0.125
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
GP Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Interviewer Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

CR2 cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the village council level.

Table A-9: OLS estimates of the effect of migration on protest participation and community meeting attendance among left behind households

	Political protest			Community meetings		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Household migration (1=Yes, 0=No)	-0.045** (0.013)	-0.035* (0.014)	-0.034* (0.013)	-0.064* (0.029)	-0.034 (0.031)	-0.032 (0.031)
Scheduled Caste (1=S.C., 0=General)		0.093** (0.032)	0.102** (0.037)		0.142** (0.046)	0.178** (0.049)
Other Backward Class (1=O.B.C., 0=General)		0.056* (0.025)	0.081** (0.025)		0.084* (0.038)	0.098* (0.042)
Muslim (1=Muslim, 0=General)		0.115** (0.029)	0.120** (0.031)		0.118* (0.048)	0.073 (0.055)
Land ownership		0.015* (0.007)	0.018** (0.006)		0.007 (0.011)	0.007 (0.010)
Asset index		0.004 (0.006)	0.004 (0.006)		0.022* (0.009)	0.023* (0.009)
Household size (1-9)		-0.001 (0.003)	-0.003 (0.004)		-0.007 (0.007)	-0.005 (0.007)
Disaster exposure (0=Very low, 3=Very high)		0.018** (0.007)	0.015* (0.007)		0.023* (0.009)	0.026** (0.010)
Crime victimization (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.025 (0.025)	0.022 (0.024)		0.057 (0.040)	0.056 (0.043)
Age (18-85)		-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.001)		0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
Gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		-0.018 (0.015)	-0.020 (0.017)		0.022 (0.029)	0.029 (0.029)
Education (1=Non-literate, 8=Graduate & above)		0.002 (0.004)	0.003 (0.004)		0.008 (0.007)	0.009 (0.007)
Government job (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.269** (0.050)	0.254** (0.048)		0.120* (0.055)	0.130* (0.060)
Observations	1417	1416	1416	1417	1416	1416
Adjusted R ²	0.004	0.092	0.140	0.003	0.028	0.069
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
GP Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Interviewer Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

CR2 cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the village council level.

Table A-10: OLS estimates of the effect of remittance transfers on benefit-claiming within left behind households

	Benefit-claiming		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Annual remittance (1=2,000 or less, 10=100,000 or more)	-0.024* (0.012)	-0.026* (0.011)	-0.024† (0.013)
Scheduled Caste (1=S.C., 0=General)		-0.239** (0.073)	-0.197* (0.088)
Other Backward Class (1=O.B.C., 0=General)		-0.157* (0.072)	-0.107 (0.078)
Muslim (1=Muslim, 0=General)		-0.251** (0.080)	-0.169† (0.098)
Land ownership		-0.104** (0.029)	-0.077* (0.034)
Asset index		0.001 (0.019)	0.000 (0.020)
Monthly household income (1=2,000 or less, 11=1,00,000 or more)		0.047* (0.023)	0.027 (0.027)
Disaster exposure (0=Very low, 3=Very high)		0.045** (0.017)	0.035* (0.017)
Crime victimization (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.117 (0.077)	0.059 (0.071)
Age (18-85)		0.000 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.002)
Gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.059 (0.050)	0.041 (0.056)
Education (1=Non-literate, 8=Graduate & above)		-0.001 (0.011)	-0.002 (0.012)
Government job (1=Yes, 0=No)		-0.144 (0.137)	-0.119 (0.148)
Observations	609	604	604
Adjusted R ²	0.007	0.048	0.127
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
GP Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Interviewer Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

CR2 cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the village council level. All models are restricted to migrant households.

Table A-11: Mean political knowledge and external efficacy among migrants and left behind individuals, by gender

Group	N	Political Knowledge	External Efficacy
Left behind Female	289	2.19	3.54
Left behind Male	98	2.53	3.77
Migrant Male	15	3.07	4.17
Migrant Female	1	3.00	3.50

Table A-12: OLS estimates of differences in political attributes between migrants and left behind individuals

	Political knowledge			External efficacy		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Migrant (1=Yes, 0=No)	0.789** (0.245)	0.537† (0.277)	0.365 (0.379)	0.529* (0.245)	0.411 (0.282)	0.055 (0.300)
Scheduled Caste (1=S.C., 0=General)		-0.095 (0.174)	-0.254 (0.185)		-0.098 (0.223)	-0.097 (0.291)
Other Backward Class (1=O.B.C., 0=General)		-0.076 (0.164)	-0.187 (0.181)		0.058 (0.181)	0.168 (0.250)
Muslim (1=Muslim, 0 =General)		-0.084 (0.183)	-0.087 (0.234)		0.276 (0.202)	0.078 (0.279)
Land ownership		-0.075 (0.104)	-0.067 (0.124)		-0.036 (0.060)	-0.034 (0.070)
Asset index		0.096* (0.039)	0.042 (0.042)		0.066 (0.042)	0.084 (0.053)
Household size (1-9)		0.000 (0.032)	0.023 (0.037)		-0.011 (0.031)	0.013 (0.036)
Disaster exposure		-0.003 (0.036)	-0.041 (0.044)		0.066 (0.043)	0.046 (0.050)
Crime victimization (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.026 (0.157)	0.209 (0.187)		-0.126 (0.191)	-0.065 (0.238)
Age (18-85)		-0.010* (0.004)	-0.013** (0.004)		0.004 (0.005)	0.001 (0.006)
Gender (1=Male, 0=Female)		0.372** (0.122)	0.599** (0.131)		0.054 (0.172)	0.236 (0.187)
Education		0.027 (0.027)	0.003 (0.033)		0.045 (0.029)	0.044 (0.031)
Government job (1=Yes, 0=No)		0.121 (0.256)	0.362 (0.243)		0.318 (0.314)	0.410 (0.394)
Observations	403	403	403	403	403	403
Adjusted R ²	0.027	0.085	0.144	0.006	0.034	0.217
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
GP Fixed Effects	No	No	No	No	No	No
Interviewer Fixed Effect	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes

† $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

CR2 cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the GP level. Sample restricted to current migrants and left behind members in active migrant households.